



THE ARRIVAL OF THE ZEPPELIN *Hindenburg* in Lakehurst, New Jersey, on May 6, 1937, was not expected to be much of a headline event. The *Hindenburg* had already made 10 roundtrips to the United States the previous year. Still, it was the first in a new series of scheduled transatlantic flights and radio reporter Herbert Morrison was sent down to Lakehurst with a sound recordist to await its arrival. At 3:30 in the afternoon, strollers on the Manhattan streets looked up to goggle at the giant swastika-marked airship passing low over the Empire State Building – normal practice, both to give passengers a spectacular view and to publicize the airship service to New Yorkers. The *Hindenburg's* captain Max Pruss, then directed his ship southward to Lakehurst. But there were electrical storms around and he held off from landing, circling in wait of clearer weather. By the time Pruss finally began his approach to Lakehurst it was 7:00 in the evening. A light rain was falling. At 7:25, the *Hindenburg* put down mooring lines to the ground and was ready to be brought to the docking mast when a strange light appeared toward the stern of the ship. In seconds it had burst into a vast tongue of flame, and within 30 seconds, fire had engulfed the entire zeppelin.

Herb Morrison recorded his impressions of the scene with an emotional immediacy that would engrave itself on the hearts of American radio listeners when broadcast a few hours later:

TRAGIC SEQUENCE

At 7:25pm, 13 hours behind schedule, the 800ft- (244m-) long Hindenburg was approaching the mooring mast when there was a muffled bang and flames could be seen just forward of the rear fin. Within seconds nearly half the hull was ablaze and the zeppelin rapidly sank to the ground, stern first (see below). Some passengers tried to escape by jumping from windows while others slid down ropes. Just 34 seconds later all that remained was a glowing, red-hot skeleton.



“Get out of the way! Get out of the way... It’s burning, bursting into flames... this is one of the worst catastrophes in the world. Oh! The flames are climbing four or five hundred feet into the sky and it’s a terrific crash, ladies and gentlemen. There’s smoke and there’s flames, now, and the frame’s crashing to the ground... Oh, the humanity, and all the passengers screaming around here!” Remarkably, 62 of the 97 people on board escaped the inferno, though some of the survivors, including Commander Pruss, were severely burned.

The cause of the disaster has never been established. It was once generally held that static electricity had ignited hydrogen leaking from the canopy. The crew of the airship always believed it had been sabotage – a time bomb planted in the rear of the airship by anti-Nazi saboteurs wishing to embarrass Hitler’s regime. The latest theory is that the sealant used to coat the skin of the airship’s gas bag – a mixture of iron oxide and aluminum powder – was inflammable and lit by a static spark caused by a buildup of electrostatic charge from the rainstorm.

international airport at Frankfurt-am-Main, from which a pair of even larger zeppelins was at last to provide the long-dreamed-of scheduled service to the United States.

The Hindenburg

The first of these airships, the *Hindenburg*, came into service in 1936, sporting Nazi swastikas. Powered by four 1,100hp diesel engines, it could carry 50 passengers at over 80mph (128kph) in unparalleled luxury. Where the *Graf Zeppelin* had crammed its passengers into a gondola, the *Hindenburg* used part of the massive hull for passenger accommodation on two decks. The upper deck had promenades on each side where passengers could stroll and gaze through panoramic windows. There was a dining room with linen-covered tables, a writing room, and a lounge with a baby grand piano. On the lower deck were bathrooms, a shower room, the crew’s quarters, the kitchen, and a smoking room.

The latter drew attention to the *Hindenburg's* one fatal flaw: its vast envelope was filled with flammable hydrogen. The zeppelin’s designers had intended to use helium, but the United States refused to supply it. Nevertheless, German engineers were sure that the *Hindenburg* was safe. A refit in the winter of 1936–37 upgraded it to accommodate 72 passengers, and in May 1937 it was ready to resume scheduled services between Frankfurt and Lakehurst. Ambitious plans were afoot for a German–US consortium to run a transatlantic service that would employ four airships. And then came the inferno of May 6 (see panel, left). As the *Hindenburg* met its mysterious and fiery end, international airship travel also went up in flames.

Whatever the specific reasons for the *Hindenburg* disaster, statistics suggest that airships were never really safe enough for passenger transportation. Out of 161 airships built over three decades, 60 were destroyed in accidents, either through fire or structural failure. They were in any case too expensive to build and too slow to have provided the kind of mass international air travel that exists today. But for the *Hindenburg* disaster, giant rigid airships might just have found a niche as the cruiseliners of the sky. As it is, they have become no more than a remembered curiosity.

Age of the flying boat

The failure of airships left air-passenger transportation over the oceans exclusively to flying boats. In the 1930s these machines enjoyed a brief golden age as the aristocrats of long-distance airplane travel. The ascendancy of flying boats made sense in the conditions of the time. Although they were not necessarily capable of